known as Sultan Baba and Sam Baba, two km distant from each other.[13] A third, also from the Laghman region, was on a stone tablet found in Pul-i-Darunta.[14] The population of the localities in which these were inscribed may have become accustomed to being accosted by their sovereign as an epigraphic presence in their midst.

It was in south Afghanistan that the emperor first addressed his north-western subjects, on the outskirts of Kandahar. The city lies in a region sandwiched between mountains and a sandy area appropriately called Registan to its south.[15] The plain on which it stands is between the Arghandab and Tarnak rivers and commands the road going through the Tarnak valley by Ghazni to Kabul. Towards the south another route skirts Registan to Quetta and the Bolan pass, from where the Indus plains could be accessed.[16] The ancient city lay west of the modern one, about four km from it. The ruins of this old Kandahar, while eroded and robbed in most places, reveal a massive citadel in the midst of an imposing walled enclosure with a series of superimposed defences.[17] Covering several thousand square metres and rising some 35 metres above the ground, the citadel was an entirely man-made elevation, built on bedrock. Very possibly it was the location of the city's administrative centre.[18]

Sometime after 260 BCE, those resident in Kandahar (as also those who visited it) would have noticed unusual activity around an easterly facing rocky outcrop which was part of the Kaitul massif, a natural stronghold. They were sure to have noticed it because it lay close to the road to Girishk and Herat, a track frequently used by travellers and traders. They will have spotted the preparation of a trapezoidal panel which was inset into the rock and smoothened with great care. The involvement of the local government would have been apparent from the presence of officials co-ordinating the preparation of the panel on which, soon enough, a few hundred words appeared. Ancient bystanders, like us today, may have wondered why the state functionaries had chosen this particular rock for those words. Was it,